Some gaolers live distant from the prison, in houses that do not belong to the county. Non-residence is not consistent with the attention that is requisite for securing the prisoners; and preserving good order, cleanliness, etc. Over the door of some of the houses of these keepers is wrote, "Spirituous liquors sold here."

Debtors crowd the gaols (especially those in London) with their wives and children. There are often by this means, ten or twelve people in a middle-sized room; increasing the danger of infection, and corrupting the morals of children. This point ought (no doubt) to be treated with tenderness. Man and wife should not be totally separated; but no women, unless prisoners, should ever be permitted to continue so much as one night in any prison; except, perhaps, when their husbands are dangerously ill. Yet the little probability there is of an industrious woman being of much service to her family in a prison: the number of men in the same room; and of lewd women admitted under the name of wives; prove that this affair needs some regulation.

Some gaols are private property: in these the keepers, protected by the proprietors, and not so subject as other gaolers to the control of magistrates, are more apt to abuse their prisoners, when a temptation offers. One of these gaols some years ago was quite out of repair, and unsafe; and the proprietor not choosing to repair it, the gaoler to confine his prisoners took a method, that was really shocking.[1] Some years before that, a prisoner in another of these gaols was tormented with thumb-screws. The grand jury took up the case, and remonstrated to the proprietor; but in vain. I had the account from a worthy friend of mine, who was upon that very jury.[2]

Of the complaints, which I have hitherto made only in general terms, I shall give instances in the account of particular prisons. To that account I refer, for evidence and fact.

Home Circuit, were of opinion that a demand not near so much was enormous, as we see in their report dated first December, 1735 (MS. p. 21):

"Paid by the gaoler of the County of Surrey for the copy of a calendar £0 7 6
And by the gaoler of each of the other counties . . . 0 5 0

"As to these two last fees or articles, we are of opinion that they are unreasonable and no ways to be justified, etc."

[1] See account of Ely gaol.

[2] Durham.

NUMBER OF PRISONERS

In the spring, 1776, I summed up carefully the total number of prisoners in the sundry prisons. My list was as follows:

	Debtors	Felons, etc.	Petty Offenders	Total
In Middlesex, i.e. London and Westminster; together with three prisons in Southwark, viz. the King's Bench, Marshalsea, and Borough-compter .	1274	228	194	1696
In the other thirty-nine counties of England	752	617	459	1828
In the twelve counties of Wales . .	67	27	—	94
In city and town gaols . . .	344	122	—	466
	2437	994	653	4084

Petty offenders in the Welsh county gaols, blank in the third column third line, are included in the preceding number of felons, etc., 27: most of the gaols in those counties being also the county bridewells.

Petty offenders, blank in third column fourth line, are included in the number 459 of petty offenders in the thirty-nine county gaols; and in the number 122 second column, fourth line.

All that were in the county gaols besides debtors, I have reckoned in the list of felons, etc., although many were petty offenders and fines.

In the third column, under petty offenders, are included a few felons occasionally committed to bridewells.

I have found by carefully examining sundry gaols, that, upon an average, two dependants (by which I mean wives and children [1]) may be assigned to each man in prison. My computation is confirmed by the account which we have from the benevolent society at the Thatched House, 27 March, 1782, as follows. Since their institution in 1772

Discharged debtors . . .	7196
who had wives	4328
and children	13,126
Persons immediately benefited .	24,650

[1] I do not include parents, many of whom I have seen sorrowfully attending at prisons, and deeply sharing in the distress arising from the confinement of their children.